



“A good 50-60% of the global trade is in man-made fibres. But we lack the technical know-how to make fabric of international standards at competitive rates. The processing is very costly”

N. THIRUKKUMARAN
CEO, ESSTEE EXPORTS



“Surat has a lot of polyester mills for domestic manufacturing. But it’s not to the level of what China, Taiwan or Thailand do. All the fabrics that go into women’s lingerie come from Thailand. What India makes cannot be used”

RAMU RAJU
PARTNER, FASHION KNITS



“Many buyers who import from China and don’t consider India say it takes about 30-36 hours to come to Tiruppur. But they can choose from 30-40 flights to reach Guangzhou or Shanghai from New York in 12 hours”

D.M. KUMAR
CEO, EASTERN GLOBAL CLOTHING



“Our exports over the past five years have remained at \$16-\$17 billion. When we were doing \$5 billion worth of exports, Bangladesh was doing \$3 billion. Now, they are at \$40 billion. Vietnam was at \$1 billion, now they are at \$27 billion”

A. SAKTHIVEL
PRESIDENT, FEIO & EX-AEPC CHAIRMAN

cilitate India to export garments duty-free to them and import duty-free cotton from them. Similar pacts with the UK and EU are also on the anvil, which the exporters say will be game changers.

But is our house in order to meet a possible surge in demand, some wonder.

I T’S HARD TO TURN A CORNER in this city without finding a bakery. ‘Tea, coffee and snacks’ announce their boards, sometimes even in Hindi to appeal to the growing migrant workforce. In fact, it’s a marker of the presence of a garment factory nearby, as workers throng the outlets during their breaks.

Today, the exporters estimate, about 70 per cent of Tiruppur’s workforce is from North India. People from around Tamil Nadu simply don’t want to work in garment factories because they are not seen as sophisticated jobs like those involving computers. The minimum a garment worker can earn is ₹350 per eight-hour shift. The rates can go up to ₹500 a shift for a top-notch tailor. A single-needle operator can even earn ₹1,000 a shift. Including overtime, a skilled tailor can earn

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around ₹15,000 a month. But even a data-entry job with a ₹10,000 salary is preferred over it, rue the exporters.

Labour availability is a perennial problem for them. Sakthivel estimates that there is always a 10 per cent shortage—that is, 50,000-60,000 workers. Others say it could be at least twice as much. “Tomorrow, if someone advertises that they have 50,000 skilled tailors, all of them will get jobs in Tiruppur the next day. I can myself employ 70-80 tailors immediately,” says Raju.

A weekly salary concept, high attrition, rampant alcoholism, especially among the local labourers, and ensuing absenteeism take a toll on productivity. “This weekly salary concept is only killing us because we don’t have a hold on the people. I tried to make it monthly but labourers didn’t want it. Now they have money in their hand every week, and they don’t want to give that up,” says Raju. He says his factory is 20 per cent under-utilised. Again, Sakthivel differs. “Within the export category, maybe 75 per cent factories give out monthly salary. Only 25 per cent are on a weekly salary.”